

Minutes of USUCGER Annual Meeting
2:30 – 4:30 pm, February 14, 2016
Phoenix Convention Center North 122B
ASCE Geotechnical and Structural Engineering Congress

1. 2:30pm E. Kavazanjian (chair) calls meeting to order
2. Announcements (Kavazanjian)
 - a. Dr. Deborah Gooding (NSF) will lead a session on “The lowdown on National Science Foundation funding for structural and geotechnical engineers” on Monday, February 15, 2016, from 10:00 – 11:30am in Room North 120AB.
 - b. Dr. Ellen Rathje will moderate the session “NHERI: Shared-use infrastructure for research in natural hazards engineering” on Tuesday, February 16, 2016, from 10:00 – 11:30am in Room North 124B.
 - c. Dr. James Kaklamanos will present the results of his 2014 USUCGER Special Projects grant “Development of a geotechnical engineering software package in R and its implementation in the civil engineering curriculum” during the session “Novel methods of educating geotechnical & structural engineers” on Tuesday, February 16, 2016, from 10:00 – 11:30am in Room North 122C.
 - d. The Board now consists of six members, Ed Kavazanjian, Tong Qiu, Tanya Kunberger, Shidei Dashti, Ellen Rathje, and Scott Olson, and three ex officio members, Chris Meehan (Treasurer), Jeff Evans (past Board president), and Matt Evans (Webmaster). Two new Board members, one of whom should be a junior faculty member, will be elected in the fall to fill out the Board to its full complement of 8 elected members.
3. USUCGER Treasurer’s Report (delivered by Kavazanjian)
 - a. The organization has a balance of \$55,834 (as of 2/12/16) combined in the checking and PayPal accounts. The Treasurer just finished collecting dues from the 2014-15 dues cycle.
 - b. USUCGER’s current balance leaves the organization with a significant reserve that can be used for various initiatives, including an increased number of special projects.
 - c. Current membership numbers, including institutional, individual institutional, and associate members, has remained essentially static since 2013.
 - d. During the Board of Directors meeting (immediately preceding the annual meeting), the Board voted to switch to a 3-year dues cycle, starting immediately with a 2016-18 dues cycle.
 - e. There was some discussion regarding whether students should be allowed to become individual members. The board and members in attendance agreed that it was reasonable to expect faculty individual members to disseminate all USUCGER information to students. No changes to current procedures will be made based on this discussion.
4. Webmaster’s Report (delivered by Kavazanjian)

- a. Dr. Matt Evans is the current Webmaster and has served since 2008. However, Matt is ready to retire from this position.
 - b. The Board approved the appointment of Dr. Ben Leschinsky (also at Oregon State University) to replace Matt. Matt will work with Ben to bring him up to speed.
 - c. The new webmaster will be responsible for managing/improving the USUCGER website, managing the Student Travel Award, and managing the PDCA Co-op program.
 - d. Kavazanjian announced several friendly reminders from the Webmaster about posting to the list serve, including the a reminder that you must post from your registered email address or else it will be not be posted until it is screened for appropriateness by the webmaster, a request to avoid large attachments, and a reminder that job announcements sent to the list are also posted on the website for 12 months or until the webmaster is notified they have been filled..
5. Student Travel Grants
 - a. Kavazanjian reported that 17 qualifying entries were received in December 2015, and of these, 2 travel grants were awarded in January 2016 to J. Kim (Illinois) and S. Xiao (Lehigh).
 - b. Some discussion followed regarding whether more than two grants should be awarded next year, but the decision was left up to the Board.
6. 2016 Election cycle
 - a. Kavazanjian reported that the Board was still two members short of its full complement of 8 members, despite having just elected Directors Rathje and Olson in 2015.
 - b. Two new members will elected in Fall 2016.
 - c. The Board is considering extending by 1 year the terms of Kavazanjian and Qui to get the board back to a “normal” election rotation.
7. Special Project Small Grant Initiative
 - a. Kavazanjian provided details for the Special Project Initiative as well as some examples of possible projects.
 - b. The first Grant was awarded in 2014 to Prof. J. Kaklamanos.
 - c. Prof. Kaklamanos provided a brief report to the USUCGER membership regarding the development of a geotechnical engineering software package in the environment *R*, similar to the environment in MatLab. He will be presenting details during Tuesday session, and will provide slides to Kavazanjian to include with meeting slides.
 - d. The RFP for the next round Special Project Grants will be emailed to the membership after the Congress (tentatively by February 19) and will include a reporting requirement.
8. Early Career Workshop
 - a. Kavazanjian reported that other commitments prevented him from making this event happen at the 2016 Congress.
 - b. NSF is still clearly interested in supporting a workshop like this, and that it may benefit more than just early career faculty.

- c. Need a champion to lead the effort for the 2017 Congress.
 - d. No one volunteered during the meeting, so Kavazanjian asked that any interested individual contact him after the annual meeting.
9. Geotechnical and Structures Congress Student Program
- a. Kavazanjian reported on the disappointment of many USUCGER members in that the Congress had significantly increased costs for students while also decreasing their benefits (no lunch on Tuesday, no access to Monday night reception, no access to Congress closing luncheon, etc.)
 - b. The Board discussed this issue and Kavazanjian may write a letter on behalf of USUCGER to the G-I expressing our disappointment in the treatment of the student participants at the Congress.
 - c. Significant discussion followed regarding concerns of the G-I Student Participation Committee (chair Dr. Bill Kitch) related to rising student costs, although it was noted that costs for G-I students typically were much lower than student costs for other ASCE Institutes. Others noted that the SEI favors practitioner attendance at their conferences and don't emphasize student participation.
10. G-I Liaison Report (Dr. Youssef Hashash) on G-I Board initiatives and concerns
- a. Rising student costs at Congress
 - b. No mobile app for Congress
 - c. Dispute over licensure requirements for sealing design of geostructures (e.g., retaining walls). After significant negotiation, final agreement that will soon become ASCE policy is that any structure that touches the soil can be designed by a P.E., an S.E. is not required.
 - d. Discussing possibility of open access G-I and ASCE journals
 - e. Board wants to ensure that they don't carry an excessive reserve (surplus) balance, lest funds be returned to ASCE; the G-I Board therefore plans to promote additional new initiatives and special projects to use surplus.
 - f. G-I will continue and expand interaction with International Organizations through the International Activities Committee. Funds are available for member travel to International Organization conferences (usually to G-I members of International Committees to attend committee meetings).
 - g. G-I Board meetings are now open to the public.
 - h. G-I has reconfigured the Diversity Committee – it is now the Engagement and Outreach Committee.
 - i. G-I has new director, Brad Keeler.
 - j. In the next year, G-I will sponsor three specialty conferences and the GeoCongress.
 - k. G-I will be experimenting with new conference publication software as a potential replacement for the MIRA system.
 - l. G-I Board is developing a new annual operating plan.
11. PDCA-USUCGER Joint Council (reported by Kavazanjian)

- a. At the initiative of PDCA, the two organizations formed a joint council to coordinate an industry cooperative program as well as a new Student Competition (paper competition, pile prediction?) at the annual PDCA conference.
- b. The USUCGER members on the council are: Kavazanjian, Armin Stuedlein (OSU), and Muhannad Suleiman (Lehigh)
- c. USUCGER has identified 18 schools with co-op programs in response to a request from PDCA (which is considering establishing a formal co-op program).
- d. Decisions on details of the PDCE student programs were still being finalized.

12. Other Business

- a. Kavazanjian reminded the Board members to be aware that some colleges and universities (including institutional members of USUCGER) were pressuring prospective graduate students to commit to graduate school offers prior to April 15. However, there is a Memorandum of Understanding (MOU) signed by nearly all institutional members of USUCGER to not require prospective graduate students to commit to offers before April 15, so this behavior is, in general, not acceptable. The MOU allows any student the right to change his mind (renege on a commitment) prior to April 15 without any penalty. After April 15, the student must obtain a written release from an institution he has previously committed to.
- b. Discussion of USUCGER mentoring program. Kavazanjian reported that this program was not successful, largely because suitable mentors did not sign up. The Board will review to determine whether the program can be reconfigured. Dr. Dave Frost mentioned that perhaps USUCGER could sponsor a mentoring “speed dating” session at a future GeoCongress.
- c. DFI representative described DFI’s interest in working closely with the G-I and USUCGER to utilize speakers’ bureau, participate in DFI student paper competition and technical committees. She reported that student membership in DFI is free, and faculty membership is inexpensive.

13. The meeting was adjourned at 4:30pm.